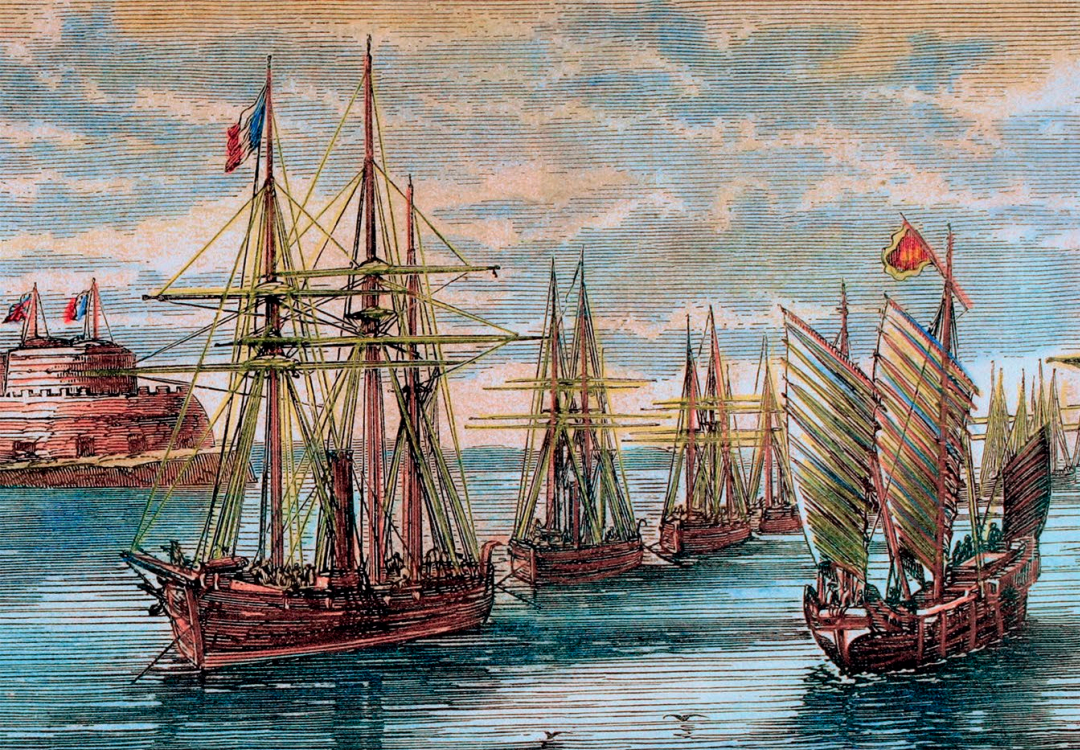




1856-60

SECOND OPIUM WAR

Between 1856 and 1860, China was at war with the British and French empires over issues relating to the opium trade. Despite significantly outnumbering the foreign forces, the Qing army proved unable to prevent them capturing the imperial capital Beijing and destroying the Summer Palace. Defeated, the Qing had to legalize the opium trade, open more ports to foreign traders, and cede the Kowloon Peninsula to the British.

◁ Anglo-French forces land at Beitang, China

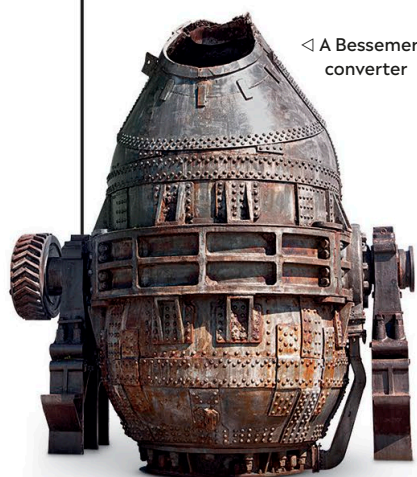
1856 Bones found in the Neander Valley, Germany, are recognized as a distinct hominid species, later named *Homo neanderthalensis*

1859 Spain declares war on Morocco over attacks on the Spanish enclave there

1859

1858 Mexico's War of the Reform pits liberals against conservatives; it ends in 1860

1859 The French conquer Saigon in Vietnam during the Cochinchina Campaign



◁ A Bessemer converter

1855

BESSEMER TRANSFORMS STEEL PRODUCTION

English inventor Henry Bessemer patented his converter for making steel. Molten pig iron was poured into the vessel and blasted with air to burn off impurities. Highly efficient, it marked the beginning of mass steel production.



△ The Sepoy Rebellion, illustration

1857-58

INDIAN REBELLION

A mutiny among the Indian sepoy (soldiers) over cartridges for the new Enfield rifles at the British garrison at Meerut on 10 May 1857 ignited a revolt against the British in India's Gangetic heartland. In the revolt's wake, British Crown rule – the Raj – was established across India.